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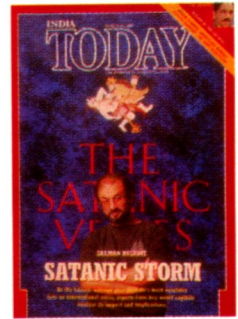
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I must confess I am not much of a reader of fiction. I first read acclaimed author V.S. Naipaul's *An Area of Darkness*, in 1964, a semi-autobiographical account of his first visit to India, the land of his forefathers. It was a scathing attack on Indian society. Most of it was true, but no one had written about it so brutally. I was a student in London and I recall being enraged at him for having exposed us to the world. One of his most memorable observations was: "Indians defecate everywhere... on the beaches; they defecate on the hills; they defecate on the riverbanks; they defecate on the streets; they never look for cover." His travel writing has been less well received by critics for his unsympathetic portrayal of the Third World.

Sir Vidia Naipaul was awarded the Nobel Prize for Literature in 2001. We Indians, as we are apt to do, have embraced him as one of our own though he was born and grew up in Trinidad before moving to Britain. Fortunately, his initial distaste witnessed in the *An Area of Darkness* later changed to grudging affection (*India: A Million Mutinies Now*). Controversy and Naipaul, however, are no strangers. He once stated that the rise of Hindutva embodied the broader civilisation resurgence of India. For all that, Naipaul, who became the first person of Indian origin to win the Booker Prize, is arguably the world's greatest living writer. In a literary career spanning 50 years, he has produced novels, essays and travel books that are remarkable for their unique style, depth and his attempt to make sense of a world condemned by the passage of history and the challenges of assimilation. Both his India-related novels, *Half a Life* (2001) and *Magic Seeds* (2004) were exclusively excerpted in INDIA TODAY and we were the first publication to interview the famously reclusive writer, on the novels. Now 74 and 29-books old, he is ready with his latest book, *A Writer's People*, and once again we are the first publication to get exclusive rights to the yet-to-be-published book. As always, there will be considerable controversy over its contents, as he is at his irascible best, or worst, debunking some cultural icons.

Executive Editor S. Prasannarajan, who has interviewed Naipaul earlier and reviewed his recent books, analyses the latest one and puts it and the writer in perspective. India is a major concern of the book, which also talks about Naipaul's Indian ancestry, his initial struggle as a writer, other writers and historical figures like Gandhi and Nehru. Anything to do with Naipaul, specially the publication of a new work, has a special resonance in India. His world is a fascinating place, often turbulent, contrary, contentious, a constant clash between ideas and reality. This book offers a fascinating insight into the mind of one of the world's literary giants and we are privileged to be the first to bring it to Indian readers.

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Our March 1989 cover